FIXING PILOT TRAINERS

India wants its flying schools to train the pilots needed for a rapidly expanding aviation industry. But the new rankings by aviation regulator DGCA are already being questioned by unhappy flying academies

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Photograph by CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

30-40k
No. of new pilots India is projected to need over the next decade

1,652
Commercial Pilot Licences issued in 2025, up from 1,347 in 2024

385
training aircraft with Flying Training Organisations, up from 324 in two years

Pilots in India have recently been in the spotlight for all the wrong reasons, the latest example being the Air India pilot who tested positive for drugs following a severe mid-air crisis on a Phuket-Delhi flight in early August. India is also projected to need 30,000-40,000 new pilots over the next decade. And the government wants these pilots to 'Train in India, Fly in India' as well.

Which is why a significant overhaul of the pilot training ecosystem is under way. As part of that initiative, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has begun ranking all approved flying training organisations (FTOs) every six months. These rankings are based on five parameters—assisting students, safety, performance, operational capability and compliance—with four grades, A+ being the highest and C the lowest (see boxes, *The Scorecard* and *How the Rankings Work*). Two rounds have already been conducted, the first in October 2025 and another this April. The picture they present is not an encouraging one. Not one FTO—not even the government's own—got the top grade in the inaugural round, prompting civil aviation minister K. Ram Mohan Naidu to say, "Now we know where we stand."

Things improved marginally in the second round, with an FTO finally